

MORE WAYS TO CONNECT THAN EVER. LESS CONNECTION.

Twenty conversations on how young adults connect socially — and why the bar keeps winning.

Picture the **school cafeteria**. Everyone in the same room, nobody mingling, the groups never touching. It's loud, it's crowded, and it's where everyone goes without ever deciding to. **Recess**, however, is right outside. You pick what you want to do, people mix, it's actually fun. But recess always came second. It was what you got to after lunch, if there was time. Right now, we're stuck in the cafeteria. Not because we like it, but because it's the default: reliable, familiar, and routine. *It's time to ring the bell.*

The bar is the cafeteria.

We didn't choose it.

We just never left.

73-79%

of Gen Z report loneliness, the highest of any generation

12.8 → 5.0

hours a week with friends, ages 18-29, 2010-2025

72% → 50%

of 18-34s drink alcohol — from the likeliest age to the least likely

50%

more likely to die early — mortality risk carried by weak social relationships

METHOD | **SAMPLE** n = 20 · **AGES** 23-28 · **GENDER** 14 men, 6 women · **CITIES** 7 · **QUESTIONS** 7, open-ended

0/20

Not one person made a friend at a bar.

Every setting they named was one they went back to.

- **Meeting people isn't hard — making new friends is.** It takes repeated time with the same people, and almost nothing in adult life provides that.
- **Open to new people, wary of strangers.** Every path to meeting someone new ran through someone they already knew.
- **Friend groups don't merge.** The problem isn't that people are alone. It's that the groups never touch.
- **Discovery is not the bottleneck.** People are flooded with options, not starved. Another events feed solves a problem nobody has.
- **Apps are good at logistics, bad at people.** "It's easy to find things to do. Not as easy to find people to do them with." — 28, Syracuse.
- **Partiful was the only app anyone volunteered as useful.** It organizes the invite, but not the occasion, so you end up talking to the people you came with.
- **Everyone described the same perfect day:** a quiet morning, something active with friends, a shared meal, games at night. Alcohol is never the point.

THE 4 CORE PROBLEMS

1. Finding **the right people** who want to do the same things.
2. **Not trusting** that events or apps have the right people.
3. **Starting conversations** with people and groups you don't know.
4. **Cost and coordination** — going out is expensive and hard to organize.

People don't go out to drink, they go out to connect!

"There are a million things happening, then I get overwhelmed, and then I don't know anyone going — so it feels like there is nothing."

— 24, LOS ANGELES —

OUR GENERATION WANTS COMMUNITY, BUT WE LACK THE INFRASTRUCTURE. *So let's build it.*